

Once a Roman colony, traces of Roman architecture are spread across the city, especially around the central city area. This is interspersed with Islamic influences like the brilliant blue domes that are visible across the skyline, giving Valencia a distinct architectural style. The city is the capital of the Valencia autonomous community, with the port and manufacturing being the main drivers of the local economy. Tourism is important too, and Valencia is a popular destination for Spaniards and Europeans alike.

The Cathedral of Valencia, built in the 1200s, stands in the heart of the city and is an important destination on the global tourist circuit. It is home to the Holy Grail, the cup that Jesus Christ is believed to have used at the Last Supper. The chalice is housed in a separate chapel in the Cathedral and is accessible for a small fee as part of the cathedral tour. For the more adventurous ones, there's the option of climbing just over 200 steps to the top of the Miguelete belltower for a birds' eye view of the city.

If that sounds too daunting, make your way to the Torres de Serranos or Serrano Towers, which were once a part of the ancient city wall.

The historic city centre or Ciutat Vella is a charming cobblestoned area which encourages visitors to walk around. The Cathedral and Basilica are located at Plaza del Reina, which is also dotted with cafes and souvenir stores. A short stroll gets you to Plaza del Ayuntamiento, home to the Valencia Town Hall and other historic buildings which have now been converted into government offices.

CULINARY HAVEN

The Mercado Central, one of Europe's largest and oldest fresh food

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1. Aerial view of Valencia City with the Torres de Serranos and narrow winding streets

2. Turia Fountain behind the Cathedral

3. View of the entrance of Valencia's Central Market

4. View of the inside of Mercado Central

